

Containing the COVID-19 Pandemic Under an External Threat: A Case Study of Taiwan

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Abstract

Given the global reach of the COVID-19 pandemic, external factors play a critical role in containing its spread and prompt questions about how such threats affect a country's response. Taiwan has received recognition for its effective management of the early stages of the pandemic, but faced significant international obstruction, especially from China. This study examines the relationship between Taiwanese citizens' trust in China and their satisfaction with the government's COVID-19 policies by analyzing data from six rounds of the Taiwan Election and Democratization Study (TEDS) conducted between 2020 and 2022. This research reveals that public opinion about China can significantly influence people's satisfaction with domestic policies, particularly during crises like pandemics. Thus, factors beyond national borders can influence public satisfaction with public health policies. The findings contribute to existing literature on shaping public opinion under external threats and have broader implications for China's impact on Taiwan's domestic politics.

Keywords: COVID-19; rally around the flag effect; trust in China; external threat

The success of governments' public health policies, especially those pertaining to COVID-19, is contingent upon the level of public satisfaction and compliance with the implemented measures.¹ Thus, it is essential to identify the factors that affect people's satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policies. Previous studies have examined domestic factors relevant to public satisfaction, such as the number of confirmed cases,² elite cues,³ and affective polarization,⁴ whereas

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¹ Philip Jäschke, Sekou Keita, Ehsan Vallizadeh, and Simon Kühne, "Satisfaction With Pandemic Management and Compliance With Public Health Measures: Evidence From a German Household Survey on the COVID-19 Crisis," *PLoS One* 18, no. 2 (2023): e0281893, <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0281893>.

² Cathy W. S. Chen, Sangyeol Lee, Manh Cuong Dong, and Masanobu Taniguchi, "What Factors Drive the Satisfaction of Citizens With Governments' Responses to COVID-19?," *International Journal of Infectious Diseases* 102 (2021): 327–31, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijid.2020.10.050>.

³ Sarah Kreps et al., "Factors Associated With US Adults' Likelihood of Accepting COVID-19 Vaccination," *JAMA Network Open* 3, no. 10 (2020): e2025594, doi: [10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2020.25594](https://doi.org/10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2020.25594).

⁴ James N. Druckman et al., "How Affective Polarization Shapes Americans' Political Beliefs: A Study of Response to the COVID-19 Pandemic," *Journal of Experimental Political Science* 8, no. 3 (2021): 223–34, <https://doi.org/10.1017/XPS.2020.28>; Erik Peterson and Shanto Iyengar, "Partisan Gaps in Political

One could argue that the actions of foreign actors can significantly influence citizens' policy judgments, either intentionally or unintentionally. For example, there have been allegations of Russia spreading misinformation during the 2016 U.S. presidential election and the COVID-19 pandemic. Studies have shown that awareness of such foreign interference can lead to support for retaliation, with the strongest effect seen when the foreign country aligns with the party that is the opposite of the respondents' party.⁶ This is in line with the "rally around the flag phenomenon," whereby citizens tend to rally behind their government when they perceive their country as being negatively affected or insulted by foreign actors.

Considering recent conversations, we suggest that interruptions in the acquisition of COVID-19 vaccines and treatments due to actions by foreign nations could influence citizens' assessments of their government's handling of the pandemic and their overall contentment with related policies. Specifically, in the context of China-Taiwan relations, we propose a negative association between trust in China and satisfaction with Taiwan's COVID-19 policy. This link is expected to be more pronounced during periods of heightened tension between the two countries and to fade as the pandemic subsides. We identify two potential mechanisms for this association: the rally effect and the scapegoat effect. The rally effect suggests that China's interference may decrease Taiwanese individuals' trust in China, thereby increasing support for the government's COVID-19 policy. Meanwhile, the scapegoat effect suggests that China's involvement may cause individuals to assign blame for policy dissatisfaction to China rather than the government, resulting in a negative correlation between trust in China and satisfaction with the government's policy.

⁹ Enrijeta Shino and Michael Binder, "Defying the Rally During COVID-19 Pandemic: A Regression Discontinuity Approach," *Social Science Quarterly* 101, no. 5 (2020): 1979–94, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ssqu.12844>.

To test our hypotheses, we used in this study six waves of nationally representative survey data from the Taiwan Election and Democratization Study (TEDS) collected between 2020 and 2022. Each wave has approximately 1,200 participants. We find empirically that Taiwanese individuals' trust in China decreases their satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policy. This study controls for possible omitted variables, such as people's trust in the incumbent Taiwanese president and people's opinions on Taiwan's economy, and, in most waves, the negative correlation is statistically significant and robust. However, when the COVID-19 pandemic stabilizes in Taiwan, satisfaction with COVID-19 policy is not associated with trust in China.

The case of Taiwan merits exploration, not only due to its distinctive international political circumstances, such as its proximity to China, but also because of Taiwan's remarkable success in effectively managing the pandemic during its early stages. Investigating the factors that contributed to Taiwanese people's evaluation of government response to the health crisis, including their perceptions about China, holds significance for the fields of international relations, public policy, and public health. Moreover, considering the structural characteristics unique to the Taiwan case, in which external threats carry intrinsic importance, the absence of a identified correlation between external threats and public satisfaction with COVID-19 policies might pose a challenge in discerning the desired correlations in other instances.

This study has theoretical implications for the current understanding of public opinion and public policy, especially in the context of managing crises and public health emergencies. The identification of a negative correlation between Taiwanese trust in China and satisfaction with the government's COVID-19 policy adds to the existing literature on how public opinion can affect policy satisfaction, especially when facing with external threats. These research findings suggest that public perceptions of external factors, such as China, can play a crucial role in shaping domestic policy decisions, particularly during times of crisis like a pandemic. The correlation between distrust in China and evaluations of major policies highlights the impact of perceptions of China on public opinion in Taiwan. Therefore, this finding has important policy implications for how foreign relations influence domestic issues.

Internal and External Factors Influencing COVID-19 Policy Satisfaction

The COVID-19 pandemic has been a global health crisis, challenging public health and politics in profound ways. Political leaders have had to conduct certain restrictive policies to contain the spread of the pandemic, such as implementing lockdowns, closing borders, and mandating mask-wearing. People's satisfaction with these policies, in turn, influences their compliance with governments' pandemic mitigation measures.¹⁰

The existing literature in political science regarding the COVID-19 pandemic has primarily centered on domestic factors that influence public support and satisfaction with government policies. For instance, the numbers of confirmed COVID-19 cases and deaths have been shown to have a direct impact on

¹⁰ Jaschke et al., “Satisfaction With Pandemic Management and Compliance with Public Health Measures.”

individuals' perceptions of government responses to the pandemic. Chen et al. conducted a cross-national study that revealed the influence of this factor on public satisfaction with government responses to the pandemic.¹¹ Additionally, party identification has been identified as a crucial factor in shaping people's evaluations of the government's performance in handling the COVID-19 crisis, as demonstrated by Chen and Fan's research on a sample from the United States.¹²

Another critical domestic factor is affective and political polarization, which can adversely affect public support for government policies aimed at curbing the spread of the virus. In the American context, affective polarization can lead to the politicization of nonpolitical issues, such as COVID-19 policies, and create a tendency to equate "the United States" with the federal government when evaluating the country's response to the pandemic, as discussed by Druckman et al.¹³ Conversely, political polarization can decrease support for policy and deepen social divisions, as highlighted by Flores et al.¹⁴ Analyzing data from Chinese respondents, Zhang et al. reported that the disclosure of information, appropriate allocation of resources,¹⁵ and timely government interventions were influential in shaping the assessments of Chinese citizens concerning their government's policies related to the COVID-19 outbreak. Despite the limited room for political polarization in autocracies, certain internal factors have exerted an impact on the evaluation of governments' performance with regard to the COVID-19 crisis.

The COVID-19 pandemic intersected with international politics, given that countries, particularly with countries with significant geopolitical power, intentionally allocated vaccines and related resources to bolster their regional dominance. China has notably pursued a form of "vaccine diplomacy" in pursuit of its national interests. Scholarly research has revealed that China has engaged in this diplomatic effort with the aim of drawing countries into its political sphere,¹⁶ vying with the United States for power and authority,¹⁷ and burnishing its national image.¹⁸ Apart from providing prompt aid, countries may also demonstrate their power and safeguard their national interests by limiting other nations' access to vital resources. In the context of the COVID-19 pandemic, China, which claims sovereignty over Taiwan and is allegedly preparing to annex Taiwan by force, has obstructed Taiwan's efforts to contain the pandemic. These intended obstructions may have two opposing effects on the Taiwanese population's evaluation of their government's COVID-19 policy. On the one hand, they can undermine the effectiveness of the COVID-19 policy and subsequently reduce Taiwanese people's satisfaction with the government's performance, especially given the pandemic's

¹¹ Chen et al., "What Factors Drive the Satisfaction of Citizens with Governments' Responses to COVID-19?"

¹² Cathy W. S. Chen and Tsai-hung Fan, "Public Opinion Concerning Governments' Response to the COVID-19 Pandemic" *PLoS One* 17, no. 3 (2022): e0260062.

¹³ Druckman et al., "How Affective Polarization Shapes Americans' Political Beliefs."

¹⁴ Flores et al., "Politicians Polarize and Experts Depolarize Public Support."

¹⁵ Yanzhe Zhang, Bowen Zou, Huai Zhang, and Jian Zhang, "Are Chinese Citizens Satisfied with Lockdown Performance during the COVID-19 Outbreak Period? A Survey from Wuhan, Shulan, and Nanjing" *Public Organization Review* (2023), <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11115-023-00698-1>.

¹⁶ Chen, "The Crisis of COVID-19."

¹⁷ Nguyen Cong Tung, "US-China COVID-19 Vaccine Diplomacy Competition in Vietnam: Where Vaccines Go, Influence May Follow," *Australian Journal of International Affairs* 76, no. 6 (2022): 653–71, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10357718.2022.2077302>.

¹⁸ Seow Ting Lee, "Vaccine Diplomacy: Nation Branding and China's COVID-19 Soft Power Play," *Place Branding and Public Diplomacy* 19, no. 1 (2023): 64–78, <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41254-021-00224-4>.

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²³ Stormy-Annika Mildner et al., “Export Controls and Export Bans over the Course of the COVID-19 Pandemic,” *BDI* (2020): 1–8.

When the central government of China imposed a lockdown in Wuhan on 23 January 2020, several nations arranged charter flights to evacuate their stranded citizens. However, Taiwan and China became embroiled in a disagreement regarding the evacuation of Taiwanese nationals from Wuhan. Taiwan's government expressed concerns about the citizenship of the passengers to board the charter planes, because Taiwan's quarantine capacity was limited. In contrast, China accused Taiwan of overreacting to the screening protocols for the passengers.²⁵ Moreover, both sides were insistent on using their own national airlines as the charter flights, which touched the sensitive cross-Strait relationship and highlighted lack of trust between Taiwan and China.²⁶

As of May 2021, just 1.3 percent of Taiwan's population had received their first dose of the COVID-19 vaccine. Because of a sharp increase in the number of confirmed cases, Taiwan is under pressure to secure vaccine supplies. However, when it attempted to acquire BioNTech (BNT) vaccines from Germany, Taiwan encountered resistance from China. Taiwan's president publicly accused China of obstructing the country's vaccine procurement efforts. Although Shanghai Fosun Pharmaceutical Group offered to supply BNT-Pfizer COVID-19 vaccines to Taiwan, the Taiwan government declined the offer for the reason of sovereignty and dignity. These concerns were exacerbated by the Chinese government's

²⁸ Reuters Staff, “Taiwan Says WHO Ignored Its Coronavirus Questions at Start of Outbreak,” *Reuters*, 24 March 2020, accessed 17 October 2023. <https://www.reuters.com/article/us-health-coronavirus-taiwan-idUSKBN21B160>.

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A Theory on Trust in China and COVID-19 Policy Satisfaction

We anticipate that there is a significantly negative correlation between the level of trust Taiwanese individuals have in China and their satisfaction with the

³⁰ Dario Cvencek, Andrew N. Meltzoff, and Manu Kapur, "Cognitive Consistency and Math-Gender Stereotypes in Singaporean Children," *Journal of Experimental Child Psychology* 117 (2014): 73–91, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jecp.2013.07.018>; Bertram Gawronski and Fritz Strack, *Cognitive Consistency: A Fundamental Principle in Social Cognition* (New York: Guilford Press, 2012); Bertram Gawronski et al., "Understanding the Relations between Different Forms of Racial Prejudice: A Cognitive Consistency Perspective," *Personality & Social Psychology Bulletin* 34, no. 5 (2008): 648–65, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167207313729>.

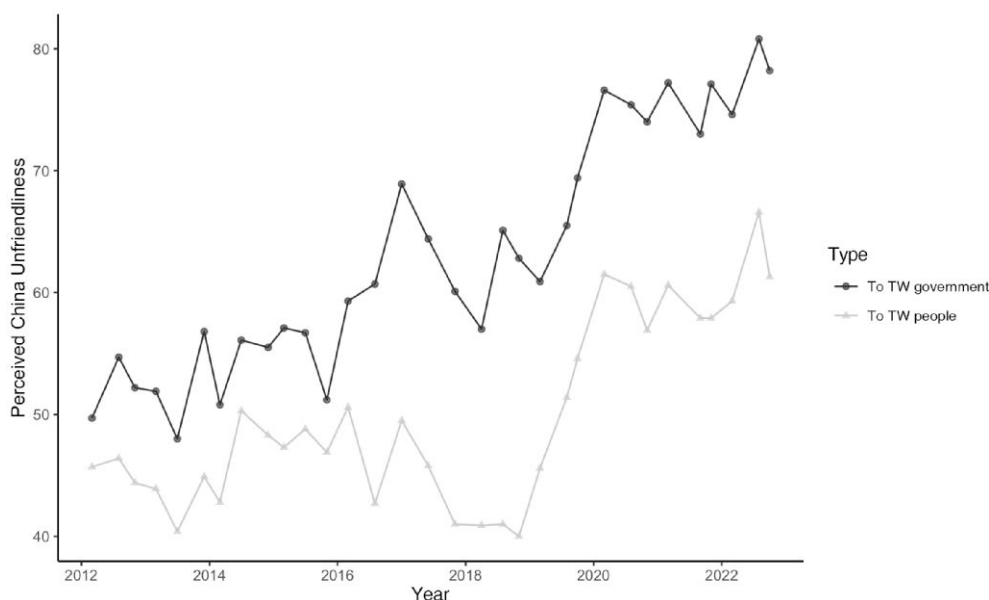


Figure 1. Taiwanese Perceptions of China's Hostility, 2012–2022. TW, Taiwan. Source: Mainland Affairs Council, Taiwan

COVID-19 policies during periods of heightened tensions between the two regions, as witnessed in the early stages of the pandemic. However, it is expected that this correlation will weaken as the pandemic comes under control. In our study, we assessed the connection between trust in China and satisfaction with COVID-19 policies.³¹ We put forth speculations about two possible mechanisms that could explain this correlation. Nevertheless, we should note that, owing to limitations in available data, we did not directly investigate these suggested mechanisms in our research. Recent articles published in the *American Journal of Political Science* have empirically tested correlations and offered theoretical explanations for the underlying mechanisms.³² Following this path, we propose two possible mechanisms that attain to the hypothesized correlation: the rally-round-the-flag effect and the scapegoat effect.

Mechanism 1: The Rally 'Round the Flag Effect

The “rally ‘round the flag effect” posits that Taiwanese people who perceive China's covering the pandemic and banning the export of masks, protective suits, and goggles overseas as a threat to their health may decrease their trust in China, thereby increasing their support for the Taiwan government's COVID-19 policy. The heightened perceived threat posed by China is expected to rally individuals

³¹ Threat may come from political and military pressure, which is constantly perceived by Taiwanese people. But we argue that distrust in China comes from China's covering the pandemic and interference in Taiwan's deal with the pharmaceutical companies for COVID-19 vaccines. It is not constant all the time. China's occasional gestures of goodwill may affect perceptions. A notable instance occurred on 18 September 2022, when Zhu Fenglian, a spokesperson for the Taiwan Affairs Office, China, expressed concern over the earthquakes in Hualien and Taitung. On the same day, Mainland Affairs Council restarted accepting the application for entry to Taiwan from China for business trips.

³² Chagai M. Weiss, Alexandra A. Siegel, and David Romney, “How Threats of Exclusion Mobilize Palestinian Political Participation,” *American Journal of Political Science* 67, no. 4 (2022): 1080–95. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12718>.

The rally around the flag effect has been extensively studied in the fields of political science and psychology.³³ It suggests that during a crisis or national emergency, individuals tend to unite in support of their leaders, regardless of their political beliefs or affiliations.³⁴ This effect is frequently observed during times of war or natural disasters, when people set aside their differences and come together to address the crisis. People who approve of the leader's handling of the crucial issue may become more favorable toward his or her issue position.³⁵

The existing literature acknowledges that partisanship can be related to the rally around the flag phenomenon, as emphasized by Shino and Binder.³⁷ This indicates that individuals' political affiliations and biases can influence how they perceive and respond to crises, potentially weakening the effect of the rally around the flag phenomenon. Despite this, the COVID-19 pandemic has shown that the rally effect has been observed in many countries. For instance, as depicted in [figure 2](#), from January 2020 to April 2021, greater than 50 percent of Taiwanese citizens were satisfied with President Tsai Ing-wen's performance. It is worth noting that the rally effect's impact may vary across different regions and periods, and its relationship with partisanship warrants further investigation.

Mechanism 2: The Scapegoat Effect

³³ John E. Mueller, *War, Presidents, and Public Opinion*. (New York: John Wiley & Sons, 1973); John R. Oneal and Anna Lilian Bryan, "The Rally 'Round the Flag Effect in U.S. Foreign Policy Crises, 1950-1985," *Political Behavior* 17, no. 4 (1995): 379-401; Marc J. Hetherington and Michael Nelson, "Anatomy of a Rally Effect: George W. Bush and the War on Terrorism," *Political Science and Politics* 36, no. 1 (2003): 37-42. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1049096503001665>.

³⁵ Chia-hung Tsai and Tsung-han Tsai, “Explaining Change in Independence–Unification Views in Taiwan: A Within-Between Model,” *Asian Journal of Communication* 32, no. 2 (2022): 111–30.

³⁷ Shino and Binder, “Defying the Rally During COVID-19 Pandemic.”

³⁸ John Maikomo Moses, Tordue Simon Targema, and Jesse Ishaku, "Tale of an Ill-fated Scapegoat: National Security and the Struggle for State Regulation of Social Media in Nigeria," *Journal of Digital Media & Policy*

Given the increasing political polarization in Taiwan, trust in China may not be the only factor influencing satisfaction with the COVID-19 policy. An alternative perspective suggests that an individual's political alignment may have a more significant impact on their trust in China.⁴⁰ Studies indicate that pro-independence

⁴⁰ Cal Clark and Alexander C. Tan, “Political Polarization in Taiwan: A Growing Challenge to Catch-all Parties?,” *Journal of Current Chinese Affairs* 41, no. 3 (2012): 7–31, <https://doi.org/10.1177/186810261204100302>; Ming-hua Huang, “Popular Discontent, Divided Perceptions, and Political Polarization in Taiwan,” *International Review of Sociology* 21, no. 2 (2011): 413–32, <https://doi.org/10.1080/03906701.2011.581809>; Syaru Shirley Lin, “It’s Not Just China: Population, Power Generation, Political Polarization, and Parochialism Are Also Long-Term Threats to Taiwan’s Success and Survival,” *China Leadership Monitor* no. 68 (1 June 2021), accessed 22 October 2023, https://www.prcleader.org/_files/ugd/af1ede_557eb203a4144cc6cb73ad4e724b3b4d4.pdf.

individuals are less likely to trust China, whereas pro-unification individuals may exhibit higher levels of trust. Additionally, it is possible that people's opinions of the Tsai administration could also influence this relationship. Therefore, the correlation between trust in China and satisfaction with Taiwan's COVID-19 policy may occur randomly when controlling for or considering these factors in the models.

We anticipate that the influence of an individual's trust in China on their evaluation of the government's COVID-19 policy would decrease as the pandemic situation stabilizes. This stems from the fact that China's engagement was predominantly noted in the early phases of the outbreak, thereby influencing people's perception of China during that period. Conversely, people's memories of China's early involvement may have faded in 2022, 2 years from the outbreak. Additionally, other issues have arisen and diverted people's attention from "the China factor," with regard to their assessment of the COVID-19 policy. There has been a notable discussion surrounding the efficacy of the COVID-19 vaccines produced by Medigen, a Taiwanese manufacturer. Additionally, there are accusations that it was unlawful for the government to procure millions of Medigen vaccines prior to their efficacy being confirmed. Gradually, these debates may result in reducing an individual's trust in China on their evaluation of the government's COVID-19 policy.

Based on the above discussion, there are two research hypotheses for empirical testing:

H1: Taiwanese people's trust in China is negatively associated with their satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policy.

H2: The effect of interest—a negative association between Taiwanese people's trust in China and their satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policy—will decrease as the pandemic winds down.

Data and Variables

For this research, we used six datasets to provide a comprehensive analysis of public attitudes toward trust in China and policy views in Taiwan. Quarterly telephone surveys are conducted by TEDS.⁴¹ The TEDS surveys offer a broad range of responses from both landline and cellular sources, and have been conducted over a prolonged period. The surveys use a systematic approach to sampling, which involves selecting household telephone numbers from phonebooks and randomly sampling cellular phone numbers based on communication service provider prefixes. For details about each dataset, please see [Table A1](#).

This study's objectives include investigating various factors, such as people's satisfaction with the government's response to the pandemic, their level of trust in the Chinese government and the Taiwanese president, as well as their self-identity, political affiliation, stance on the unification versus independence issue, gender, education, and age. The outcome variable, satisfaction with the government's handling of the pandemic, is measured as an ordinal-level variable with four

⁴¹ Data analyzed in this article are from Taiwan's Election and Democratization Study, 2020–2024 (III): Telephone and Mobile Phone Interview Survey of the Presidential Satisfaction. The coordinator of the multiyear project TEDS is Professor Lu-huei Chen (National Chengchi University). More information is on the TEDS website (<http://www.tedsnet.org>; date accessed 26 October 2023.). The authors appreciate the assistance of the institute and the aforementioned individuals in providing data. The authors are alone responsible for views expressed herein.

possibly due to the implementation of measures such as temperature checks, social distancing, isolation, quarantine, and closure of public areas. In January 2021, the government responded to a surge in confirmed cases by tightening quarantine requirements for inbound travelers.

The first shipment of the Oxford-AstraZeneca COVID-19 vaccine arrived in Taiwan in March 2021. However, Taiwan faced challenges in acquiring the German BNT vaccine due to China’s intervention. The resulting conflict involving Taiwan, BNT, and Shanghai Fosun—the exclusive distributor of BNT products in mainland China, Hong Kong, Macau, and Taiwan—quickly escalated. At the same time, the number of confirmed cases and deaths sharply increased in April and May. As a consequence, schools were closed and remote work was advised.

Despite a vaccination rate of almost 70 percent, which was made possible through donations from countries such as the United States, Japan, and Poland, confirmed cases continued to increase steadily. The government’s approval rating also fell to approximately 60 percent. In 2022, the emergence of the Omicron variant led to a significant increase in confirmed cases in Taiwan, although satisfaction levels with the government rebounded in March before declining again in September. In May 2022, Taiwan abandoned its zero-COVID policy to prevent overwhelming the medical system in response to the mounting pressure from the surge in confirmed cases and deaths. In July 2022, the border was reopened and the quarantine and isolation measures were relaxed.

Independent and Control Variables

The levels of confidence that individuals have in the Chinese government and President Tsai are illustrated in figures 4 and 5, respectively. The average trust scores for the Chinese government steadily increased from 2.006 in March to 2.205 in September 2021, which coincided with the resolution of medical equipment and vaccine supply issues. However, the mean score declined to 2.132 3 months later

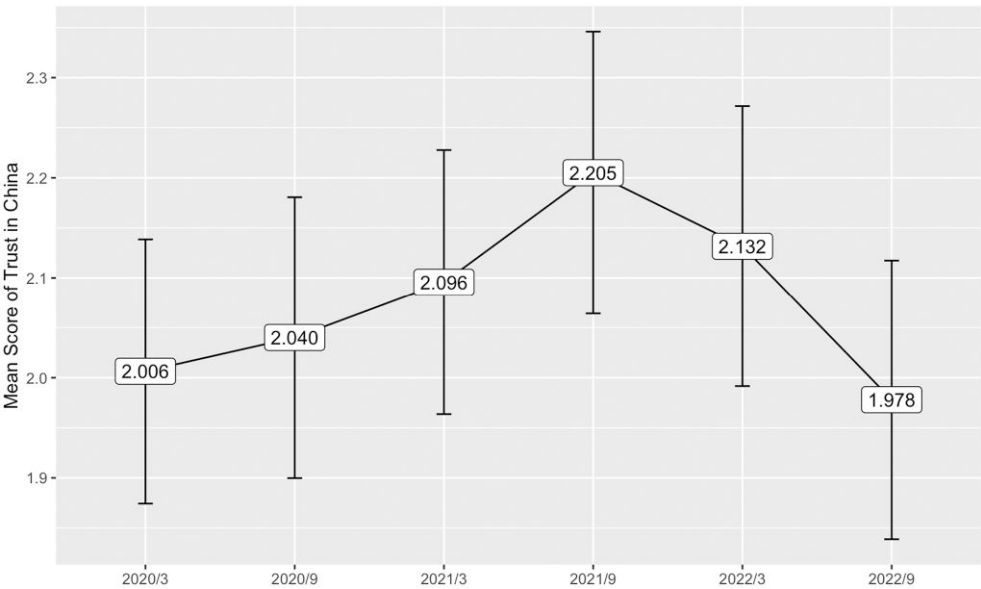


Figure 4. Trust in China, 2020–2022. Source: TEDS

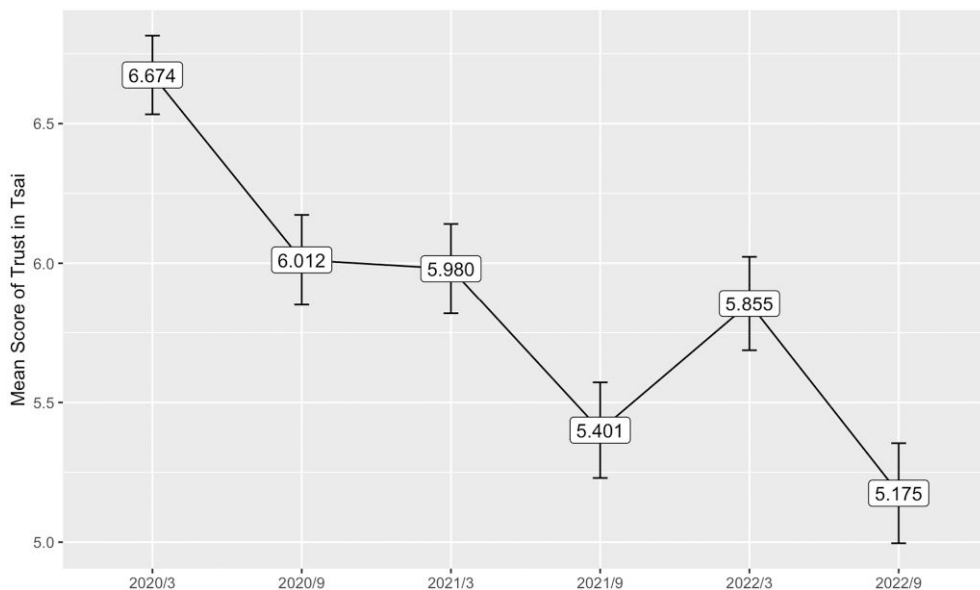


Figure 5. Trust in President Tsai, 2020–2022. Source: TEDS

and further decreased to 1.978 by September 2022. The lockdowns imposed in Shanghai and other cities may have played a role in the erosion of trust in China.

Figure 5 shows a downward trend in confidence in President Tsai throughout the pandemic. The lowest level was observed in September 2022 (5.175); the second-lowest level was in September 2021 (5.401). This decline in trust in President Tsai appears to correspond with the decreasing satisfaction with the government's pandemic response. Figures 4 and 5 display nearly opposing patterns, with individuals expressing trust in President Tsai and distrust in China at almost the same time. In other words, these two attitudes have opposing impacts on the dependent variable. Within our models, trust in China serves as the principal independent variable, and trust in President Tsai is a crucial controlled variable.

In our models, we not only controlled for trust in President Tsai but also accounted for other critical variables. The assessment of the economy by Taiwanese citizens is a potential variable, given that their perspectives on the economy could have influenced their trust in China, especially considering China's status as Taiwan's foremost trade partner. Moreover, Taiwanese people's assessments of the economy could also affect their satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policy because various measures and policies, such as lockdowns and travel bans, had a significant impact on Taiwan's economy. In addition, our models included respondents' gender, education, national identity, age, and political affiliation.

Some may argue that China's perceived threat has remained consistent since 1949, making it challenging to account for fluctuations in the dependent variable. Our perspective, however, is that although China's overarching ambition to assert control over Taiwan may have remained constant, the specific actions it has taken as part of its preparations have evolved over time. What is more pertinent and relevant to our research is how the Taiwanese population perceives China. If their perceptions fluctuated, then the constant nature of the issue may be of lesser concern. According to figure 1, data from the periodic surveys demonstrate that Taiwanese perceptions of China's hostility toward Taiwan's government and its people have

Table 1. Estimates of Ordinal Probit Regression Models, 2020–2022

Variable	TEDS Survey Waves: Date				
	3/2020	9/2020	3/2021	9/2021	3/2022
Trust in China	−0.071*** (0.018)	−0.040* (0.018)	−0.082*** (0.02)	−0.018 (0.018)	−0.064*** (0.017)
Trust in President Tsai	0.196*** (0.021)	0.218*** (0.019)	0.252*** (0.02)	0.274*** (0.019)	0.244*** (0.018)
Economic evaluation	0.176* (0.075)	0.080 (0.064)	0.241** (0.092)	0.306*** (0.058)	0.089 (0.058)
National identity (reference group, Chinese identity)					
Taiwanese	0.306 (0.197)	0.772*** (0.171)	−0.044 (0.210)	−0.026 (0.194)	0.278 (0.180)
Dual identity	0.2634 (0.195)	0.500** (0.167)	−0.401 (0.202)	−0.288 (0.191)	0.255 (0.176)
Partisanship (reference group, Independents)					
KMT	0.272* (0.124)	0.020 (0.109)	0.079 (0.109)	−0.115 (0.115)	0.012 (0.113)
DPP	0.1928 (0.107)	0.356*** (0.112)	0.301** (0.117)	0.358*** (0.099)	0.124 (0.099)
Other parties	0.355* (0.151)	−0.113 (0.146)	0.195 (0.167)	−0.269* (0.125)	−0.097 (0.131)
Female sex	−0.0311 (0.083)	−0.0721 (0.082)	−0.038 (0.084)	0.247*** (0.076)	0.034 (0.075)
Age, years (reference group age range = 20–29 years)					
30–39	0.098 (0.138)	0.036 (0.132)	0.102 (0.138)	0.034 (0.118)	−0.014 (0.118)
40–49	0.125 (0.137)	0.044 (0.131)	−0.114 (0.136)	0.197 (0.119)	0.147 (0.119)
50–59	0.188	−0.098	−0.015	0.182	−0.006

(continued)

Table 1. Continued

Variable	TEDS Survey Waves: Date					
	3/2020	9/2020	3/2021	9/2021	3/2022	9/2022
≥60	(0.146) 0.261 (0.158)	(0.138) -0.253 (0.144)	(0.144) -0.109 (0.159)	(0.128) 0.253 (0.136)	(0.125) 0.033 (0.131)	(0.127) -0.092 (0.132)
Education (reference group = illiterate, elementary)						
Junior high	0.063 (0.186)	0.028 (0.198)	0.099 (0.218)	0.200 (0.197)	0.027 (0.183)	0.033 (0.167)
Senior high	0.177 (0.179)	0.024 (0.176)	0.273 (0.21)	-0.047 (0.179)	-0.056 (0.164)	-0.277 (0.154)
College	0.084 (0.195)	-0.113 (0.197)	0.592** -0.213	-0.158 (0.196)	-0.039 (0.183)	-0.348* (0.172)
University	0.248 (0.182)	-0.089 (0.184)	0.374 (0.216)	0.011 (0.183)	-0.047 (0.166)	-0.198 (0.160)
Model fit						
AIC	1,453.79	1,572.09	1,549.56	2,151.86	2,058.87	2,223.05
N	1,158	1,071	1,107	1,050	1,049	1,046

Note: The intercepts of models are not shown here. AIC, Akaike information criterion; DPP, Democratic Progressive Party; KMT, Kuomintang, Nationalist Party; TEDS, Taiwan Election and Democratization Study. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Source: TEDS.

undergone significant changes over the past decade, from 2012 to 2022. Therefore, we have confidence that Taiwanese people's threat perception of China varied systematically during the period under our exploration, from 2020 to 2022.

Finding and Discussion

Table 1 displays the estimates obtained from six ordinal probit regression models. We used the ordered probit regression model to investigate whether trust in China, trust in President Tsai, economic evaluations, partisanship, and demographic variables can predict individuals' level of satisfaction with the government's management of the pandemic, which ranges from "very dissatisfied" to "dissatisfied," "satisfied," and "very satisfied." The first column of the table presents the determinants of satisfaction with the government's pandemic response in March 2020. We found that this variable increases with distrust in China and trust in President Tsai.

Similarly, the second column demonstrates that, in September 2020, individuals who had distrust in China expressed satisfaction with the Taiwanese government's efforts in controlling the pandemic. The third column of **Table 1** presents the results of the analysis for March 2021, which marked Taiwan's first year of the pandemic and the initial reception of vaccine shipments. The findings demonstrate that trust in both China and President Tsai significantly predicts the public's evaluation of the government's handling of the pandemic. In particular, trust in China is linked to a decrease in people's satisfaction with the Taiwan government's COVID-19 policy, whereas trust in Taiwanese President Tsai is positively correlated with the dependent variable.

In addition, the assessment of economic policies implemented by the government also plays a crucial role, indicating the heightened concern of the Taiwanese population for economic relief measures. It is noteworthy that, in the latter half of 2021, trust in President Tsai remained a pivotal factor in the public's assessment, whereas trust in China did not demonstrate a significant impact. This finding is consistent with the observed trend in **figure 4**, suggesting that perceptions of China have become more neutral and, therefore, exert a smaller influence on the public's assessment of the government.

In the fifth column, both trust in China and President Tsai are significant predictors of the dependent variable in March 2022, with distrust in China negatively affecting people's assessment of the Taiwanese government's COVID-19 policy, and trust in President Tsai increasing their level of satisfaction. On the other hand, the last column of the table indicates that trust in China is not a significant factor, but trust in President Tsai remains influential as important predictors of the dependent variable. We speculated that the disappearance of the observed correlation could be attributed to the pandemic's waning phase. During this period, Taiwan's government was progressively easing COVID-19 restrictions, and people's daily routines were returning to a state of normalcy.

Our analysis indicates that trust in President Tsai is consistently associated with satisfaction levels regarding the government's pandemic response, which is expected, given the domestic nature of public health and the administration's responsibility. However, the role of trust in China is also significant, except for the periods of September 2021 and September 2022. When individuals lack trust in China, it may lead to doubts about China's willingness to cooperate in

international matters, such as managing COVID-19. People's perceptions of China can influence the pandemic response because events related to China, such as the Wuhan outbreak, hoarding of medical supplies, Taiwan's exclusion from the WHA, and interference with Taiwan's vaccine procurement, may affect public opinion.

After Taiwan secured an adequate supply of vaccines and relaxed COVID-19 restrictions in early 2022, concern over China's influence in this pandemic become less significant. For instance, the Central Epidemic Command Center reduced the mandatory quarantine period for incoming travelers to 10 days and permitted nonresidential business travelers to enter the country from 7 March. However, the Russian's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 accentuated the coercive tendency of China. Taiwan is often compared with Ukraine because China has repeatedly warned that it will not rule out using force if Taiwan declares independence. As a result, distrust in China, fueled by the Russian aggression, may have influenced people's perception of the government's pandemic response in March 2022.

To illustrate the effect of each independent variables in the six models, we use the `ordChange` function in R package *DAMisc* to compute the change in predicted probabilities at each level of the focal variable while holding the other variables constant. [Figure A1](#) illustrates that trust in Tsai is consistently the biggest impact on the response variable. The effect of trust in China on the evaluation of Taiwan's COVID-19 policy is comparatively smaller than that of other variables. To illustrate, in March 2020, a 1-unit increase in trust in China corresponded to a 0.071 decrease in the predicted probability of public satisfaction with Taiwan's COVID-19 policy. A change in trust in China also makes policy satisfaction less likely by 0.040 in September 2020. In March 2021, each unit increase in trust in China is associated with a lower predicted probability by 0.082 in satisfaction with the COVID-19 policy. However, by September 2021, the coefficient of trust in China is not statistically significant. In March 2022, a 1-unit increase in trust in China leads to a decreased predicted probability in Taiwanese people's satisfaction by 0.064. Yet again, in September 2022, this association was found to be statistically insignificant.

It could be contended that the effects of trust in China across the six survey waves are modest but substantial. The relationship highlights how China's influence could present challenges to both the quality and sustainability of Taiwan's democratic governance. Our findings reveal a potential connection between trust in a foreign nation and the effectiveness of domestic policies. Thus, despite these effects not being as pronounced as those of domestic variables, their relevance, particularly in the context of national security, is noteworthy and warrants additional exploration.

A valid concern arises that trust in President Tsai could potentially be influenced by trust in China in a post-treatment scenario, because some Taiwanese voters may shape their political preferences based on their perceptions of China. If they harbor distrust toward China, they might be inclined to support President Tsai, and vice versa. To address this specific concern, we have developed a model that excludes trust in President Tsai as a variable. The results of this analysis consistently reveal the same directional effects across all six waves of data. Notably, our primary independent variable, trust in China, demonstrates an even more substantial effect size in this context. The outcomes of this refined model can be found in [Table A3](#).

Among KMT supporters in Taiwan, who typically harbor a more positive outlook toward China, the rally around the flag and scapegoat effects could exhibit variations. These supporters are less inclined to perceive China as an imminent threat, which could temper the rally around the flag effect, characterized by a unity-seeking response to external challenges. As a result, their satisfaction with the government's COVID-19 policy may not be as significantly influenced by tensions with China. The scapegoat mechanism, whereby external entities are blamed for internal issues, might also be less pronounced among KMT supporters, due to their favorable views of China. Thus, their identity and perception of China crucially shape their response to government policies and external threats. Although a detailed subgroup analysis is beyond the scope of this research, our discussion on identity politics in Taiwan and the two mechanisms is supported by our subgroup analysis on the KMT supporter sample, too. In most of the six waves of the TEDS, the coefficients of trust in China are seldom statistically significant, suggesting that the identity of KMT supporters might diminish the effect of the two proposed mechanisms.

⁴³ C. C. Chang, W.-T. Yen, and L.-Y. Liu, "Fighting the Pandemic with "Shields": Successful COVID-19 Securitization and Mask Policy in Taiwan," *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 58, no. 2 (2023): 214–31, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00219096221137684>.

Conclusion

In summary, this study highlights a negative association between Taiwanese trust in China and their satisfaction with the Taiwanese government's COVID-19 policy. Although many studies have investigated domestic factors of public satisfaction with COVID-19 policies, the role of external threats has received limited attention. This knowledge gap poses a risk to the effectiveness of public health policies. This study addresses this gap by examining the impact of China's interference on Taiwanese individuals' satisfaction with their government's COVID-19 policy. Our findings echo the rally around the flag effect and scapegoat effect theories. Each theory explains why distrust in China shores up support for the Taiwanese government's pandemic policy.

The link between Taiwanese skepticism toward China and the population's approval of the government's COVID-19 strategy, as uncovered in this research, provides valuable perspectives on how public sentiment regarding external threats can affect satisfaction with policies. This study also enhances our understanding of international relations theory by demonstrating that a state's actions can shape its reputation and, in turn, influence public sentiment and policy assessments in other states. It underscores the importance of examining the impact of international relations on the domestic landscape through the lens of individual-level behavior.

This research has several major limitations. First, we did not directly unlock the rally 'round the flag and scapegoat effects, which await more data. Second, the study only examines China's interference as an external factor on the pandemic policy satisfaction. However, we should take influence of the United States into account, given that Taiwan has long been teaming up with the United States and accepted its vaccine donation. Taiwanese people may be more likely to express their discontent if they perceive that Singapore, Japan, or even China did a better job containing the pandemic. Furthermore, it is important to acknowledge that we did not measure how Taiwanese people perceived Taiwan's failure to procure Pfizer vaccines from Germany or the United States in early 2021. It is plausible to assume that some people may feel frustrated and change their level of confidence in China and their assessment of the policy performance of the government.

Although we have discovered a statistically significant adverse relationship between the trust of Taiwanese citizens in China and their satisfaction with COVID-19 policies, it is essential to recognize that this external threat is not the exclusive determinant of people's policy satisfaction. It is important to acknowledge that our research does not encompass the comprehensive identification of all influencing factors. We strongly encourage future studies to undertake a systematic evaluation of the various elements that affect individuals' satisfaction with public health policies and determine their respective significance. Furthermore, in common with the majority of social science studies, although we have accounted for various potential omitted variables in our models, there may still be lingering concerns related to omitted variables. Subsequent research endeavors may contemplate the use of causal inference methodologies to more accurately assess the impact of trust in China on individuals' satisfaction with public health policies.

Future investigations can extend this study by examining the effect of different external threats on public policy satisfaction in various settings. The question of whether people would support or reject the government in a crisis is a complex issue that presents a significant research challenge. Additionally, researchers could

explore how the connection between public opinion and policy satisfactions changes over time. This could be especially pertinent in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic, during which policies and public attitudes have been constantly changing.

Researchers could also investigate the impact of various individual-level factors on public policy satisfaction, such as political ideology, socioeconomic status, and demographic characteristics. These factors may contribute to a more nuanced understanding of the drivers of public opinion and policy evaluations during crises.

Supplementary Material

[Supplementary material](#) is available at *Political Science Quarterly* online.